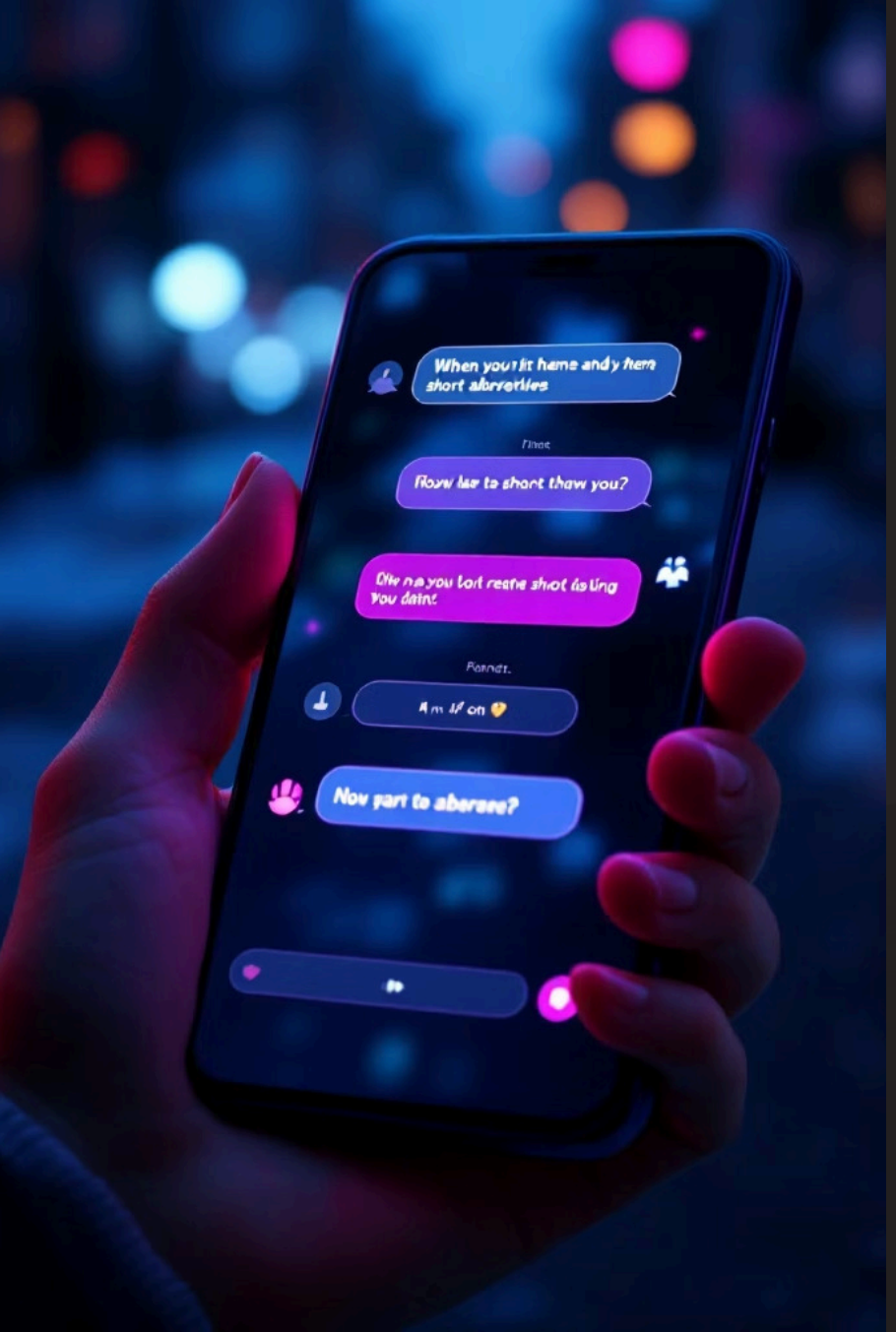
Communication: Informal Habits in Formal Spaces

How everyday digital habits quietly undermine professional impressions — and what students can do about it.

PART 4

Made with GAMMA



The Email That Backfired

Arjun needed a faculty recommendation for a summer internship. Pressed for time, he sent what felt like a perfectly efficient message:

> *"Hi sir, I need recommendations urgently. Send asap."*

No subject line. No context. No polite closing. What felt efficient to Arjun read as **careless and abrupt** to his professor — and the reply made that clear.

Made with GAMMA

The Same Request, Done Right

The issue was never *what* Arjun asked — it was *how* he asked it. A revised email made all the difference.

❌ Original Message

"Hi sir, I need recommendations urgently. Send asap."

- No subject line
- No introduction or context
- Abrupt, demanding tone
- No polite closing

✅ Revised Email

Subject: Request for Internship Recommendation

Dear Sir, I hope you are doing well. I am applying for a summer internship and would value your recommendation. Your guidance has been invaluable to me...

- Clear subject and context
- Respectful, warm tone
- Acknowledges recipient's time

Made with GAMMA

How Digital Habits Blur the Line

Most student communication flows through instant messaging — quick, informal, and minimal. Over time, this style becomes **automatic**.

The problem is not ignorance. Many students have learned professional email etiquette at some point. The real issue is that **habit overrides awareness**, especially when speed feels more urgent than presentation.

Made with GAMMA

The Real Cost of Miscommunication

In casual settings, a sloppy message is quickly forgotten. In professional contexts, it leaves a lasting mark.

First Impressions

An email is often the **first point of contact** with faculty, employers, or coordinators — and first impressions stick.

Signals You Send

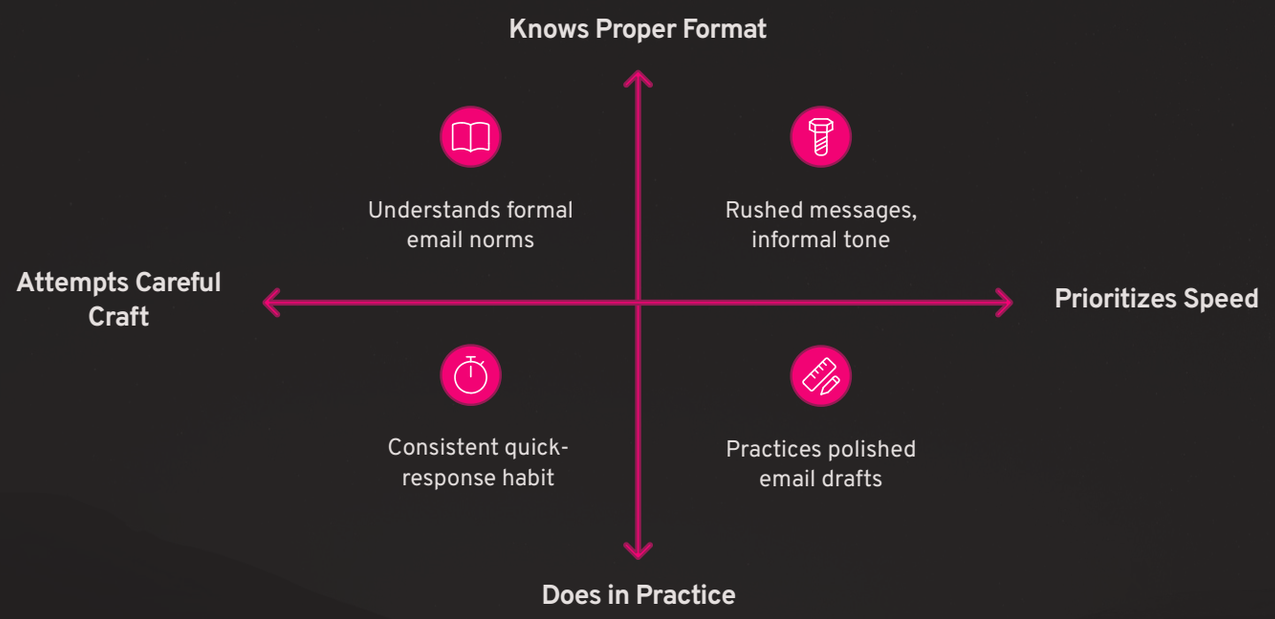
A poorly written email inadvertently signals **low effort, disrespect,** and inattention — regardless of your actual intentions.

Missed Opportunities

Arjun got a reply — but not a warm one. What could have been a **supportive exchange** became a minimal, transactional response.

Made with GAMMA

The Knowledge–Practice Gap



The Central Challenge

Students are not uninformed. The struggle is **consistent application** under real-world pressure.

This gap — between knowing the right approach and consistently applying it — is the core challenge educators and students must address together.

Awareness ≠ Action

Knowing correct etiquette does not guarantee using it when it counts most.

Context Blindness

Students often fail to recognise when a situation demands a professional register.

Habit Is the Real Barrier

Repeated informal practice rewires defaults — changing this requires deliberate effort.

Made with GAMMA